

Week One Handouts Pack

8th Grade American Studies · 2026–27 · five ready-to-print activities

What's inside: 1) Get-to-Know-You Jenga — 54 numbered questions matching numbered blocks. 2) Investigate the Teacher — clue cards you fill in, plus a student detective sheet. 3) Classroom Scavenger Hunt — students learn the room AND each other. 4) Time Machine get-to-know-you worksheet. 5) Life Map — the Unit 1 identity project launcher. Each starts on its own page for easy copying.

Name rule for everything in this pack: answers given to a partner or group always start with your first name — "I'm Maya, and my answer is..." — until everyone can prove they don't need it anymore.

1 • Get-to-Know-You Jenga

Number your Jenga blocks 1–54 with a marker. Pull a block, answer its question, stack it on top. Tower falls? Rebuild and keep talking.

Group size: 3–5 per set. **Name rule:** before you answer, say the name of the person who pulled before you.

1. What's your full name — and is there a story behind it?	28. Would you rather be a famous inventor or a famous explorer?
2. What do you want us to actually call you?	29. If you wrote a book, what would it be about?
3. Best movie you've seen this year?	30. What's one thing on your bucket list?
4. A food you will never eat, no matter what.	31. What language do you wish you spoke?
5. If you could have any superpower, what would it be?	32. What's the best gift you've ever given someone?
6. What's your go-to karaoke song (real or imaginary)?	33. Would you rather fight one horse-sized duck or 100 duck-sized horses?
7. Beach vacation or mountain vacation?	34. What's your favorite family tradition?
8. What's the best age to be? Defend it.	35. If you could interview any American from history, who?
9. If you had a time machine: past or future?	36. What's something that always makes you laugh?
10. Which decade would you visit first, and why?	37. What sport would be funniest to add to the Olympics?
11. Historical figure you'd want as a lab partner?	38. What's your ideal Saturday?
12. What's something you're weirdly good at?	39. Would you rather be able to fly or be invisible?
13. What's your comfort show — the one you rewatch?	40. If you started a business, what would it sell?
14. Cats or dogs — and make your case.	41. What's the last thing that surprised you?
15. What would you name a pet turtle?	42. Sweet or salty?
16. Best thing you did this summer in one sentence.	43. What's your best 'little kid logic' story about yourself?
17. What's a smell that reminds you of being little?	44. If our class had a mascot, what should it be?
18. If school had one extra class, what should it be?	45. What's a skill you want to learn before high school?
19. What job did you want when you were 6?	46. Who in your life gives the best advice?
20. What's your walk-up song?	47. Would you rather explore the ocean floor or outer space?
21. Would you rather live without music or without movies?	48. What's a song that puts you in a good mood instantly?
22. What's the best snack in vending machine history?	49. If you could rename this town, what would you call it?
23. Name a place you'd teleport to right now.	50. What's the best compliment you've ever gotten?
24. What's a rule you'd add to this school?	51. Would you rather live in 1776 or 2076?
25. What's a rule you'd delete from this school?	52. What's one thing you're looking forward to this year?
26. Who is the funniest person you know?	53. If you could make one thing free forever, what?
27. What's your most controversial food opinion?	54. Ask ANYONE at the table any question from this list.

2 • Investigate the Teacher

Teacher prep: answer the ten prompts below, write each answer on a clue card, and hide the cards around the room. Students hunt in pairs, record findings, and build a 'case file' on you.

Teacher clue cards — fill in and cut apart

CLUE 1 • A place I have lived:	CLUE 2 • My favorite food is:
CLUE 3 • Before/besides teaching, I once worked as:	CLUE 4 • My favorite period of American history is:
CLUE 5 • A song you might catch me humming:	CLUE 6 • My weekend hobby is:
CLUE 7 • Something about my family (kids? pets?):	CLUE 8 • A country or state I dream of visiting:
CLUE 9 • My most unpopular opinion:	CLUE 10 • Something surprising about me:

Student detective sheet

Detectives: _____ and _____

Find every clue card hidden in the room. Record what you learn. Then write your profile of the suspect.

Clue 1: _____

Clue 2: _____

Clue 3: _____

Clue 4: _____

Clue 5: _____

Clue 6: _____

Clue 7: _____

Clue 8: _____

Clue 9: _____

Clue 10: _____

The profile

Based on the evidence, describe your teacher in exactly three sentences. Bonus point: make one prediction about them that the clues do NOT prove — we'll find out during the year if you were right.

3 • Classroom Scavenger Hunt

Teams of 2–3 (randomly assigned — draw cards). First team to finish every item wins. You must trade off who writes.

1. Where do you turn in finished work? Write the exact spot.

2. Where does the Do Now appear every single day?

3. Find the WALT board. Copy today's WALT word-for-word.

4. Where do the Accountable Talk sentence stems live?

5. Where are the extra pencils? (Take nothing. Just knowledge.)

6. What's the attention signal in this class? Describe it.

7. Find the fire escape route map. Which way do we exit?

8. Where will your class period's Beat-the-Record time be posted?

9. Locate the classroom library or reading shelf. Write one title that looks interesting.

10. What do you do if you finish work early? (Hint: it's posted.)

11. Find something in this room related to the Constitution. What is it?

12. Where do absent students find what they missed?

13. Meet a team from another table: write BOTH of their first names here.

14. Get the first names of TWO people not on your team and not on the team from #13.

15. Final task: as a team, agree on the one norm from our Classroom Constitution draft you think matters most. Write it — and every team member's name — below.

4 • The Time Machine — Get to Know You

There are no wrong answers, only interesting ones. You'll share ONE answer of your choice with your table — starting with your name.

Name: _____ **What you want to be called:** _____

1. You get ONE round trip in a time machine to any moment in American history. Where and when do you go — and why?

2. Which person from the past would you bring to 2026 for a day? What do you show them first?

3. What's one thing from YOUR life that you think belongs in a museum 100 years from now?

4. You can ask any figure from history one question, and they have to answer honestly. Who, and what do you ask?

5. Would you rather live in 1776 or 2076? Convince me in two sentences.

6. What's a moment from history you wish you could have seen with your own eyes?

7. What do you think people in 2126 will find weird about how we live now?

8. History books remember big events. What's one small, ordinary thing about your summer that deserves to be recorded anyway?

5 • Your Life Map

The launch of our Unit 1 project, "Whose America?" — before we map the nation's story, you map yours.

What it is: a one-page visual map of your life so far — drawn, collaged, or diagrammed. Think of it like a road map: a path from birth to today with the stops that made you, you.

Your map must include

- ✓ At least 6 'landmark' moments — events, people, places, or changes that shaped you
- ✓ At least 1 'origin point' — where your story starts (a place, a family, a name)
- ✓ At least 2 'forks in the road' — moments where things could have gone differently
- ✓ A title that is NOT your name (name goes on the back)
- ✓ Color, symbols, or small drawings — this is a map, not an essay

Planning space

Brainstorm your landmarks here first (words only — the art happens on the big page):

Landmark 1: _____

Landmark 2: _____

Landmark 3: _____

Landmark 4: _____

Landmark 5: _____

Landmark 6: _____

How it will be shared

Gallery walk in a circle at the end of Week 1. Classmates will leave one sticky-note noticing per map — "I also...", "I want to hear more about...", or "Your map and mine connect because...". Then we ask the year's big question: if every map in this room is this different, whose story counts as the American story?

Success criteria (our 4-level scale): 1 Beginning — a few moments listed • 2 Progressing — required elements present • 3 Proficient — complete map with clear landmarks and forks • 4 Exemplary — the map makes an argument about who you are, not just a list.